

The British were motivated to invest in railways in India because of the success and profitability of the British railways. Around the time when Lord William Bentinck, Governor-General of India (1828–35), undertook road construction projects, the idea of introducing railways and constructing canals was considered for the first time in the Madras Presidency in the south where there was a growing demand for cotton for its textile industries.

It was estimated that the costs of construction and maintenance of canals vis-à-vis railways were nearly the same. However, the latter were preferred. To this effect, a rail line, with animal-drawn vehicles in southern India – from Cauvery-Pattam to Caroor – was proposed to a committee overseeing EIC affairs in Britain. The committee did not pay any attention to this proposal and it never materialized. Instead, Bentinck's administration undertook road construction and made substantial headway during 1839–49. However, roads alone could not have provided an efficient communication system and transport conditions remained poor in many parts of the country.

Deluge of proposals

Soon, the question of railways began attracting individuals with vested interests in the enterprise. In light of communication problems due to poor roads in the Madras Presidency, Sir Arthur Thomas Cotton (see [Experimental Rail Lines](#)), a civil engineer, wrote to the Inspector General of Civil Estimates in 1836 for a railway connecting Madras in the south to Bombay in the west. A member of the Board of Revenue at Madras later put forth the matter to the Madras government, stating that the railway would aid transporting salt from the southern coast. In 1837, the Court of Directors sanctioned surveys and estimates for the recommended line.